

Can Strong Cultural Norms & Stereotypes Explain Lower Suicide Rates in Rajasthan?

Examining the Paradox of Lower Literacy, Bigger Household Sizes, Plenty of Marginal Workers & Strict Cultural Norms alongside Relatively Lower Rates of Suicide using a Data Driven Approach alongside Personal & Historical Examples

Vaibhav Agarwal

(Using 1 Table, 4 Graphs & A Movie To Make One Story)

Abstract

Rajasthan, a state known for its rich ancient history of majestic rulers and bravehearts, who would sacrifice themselves had "mewar"¹ asked for it or killed themselves had Mewar distanced itself from Mewar - its people, the culture and the values. Culture, family values and beliefs formed the core of Mewar. Fast forward centuries later, emotions and values of courage, tenacity, discipline, devotion and passion still resonate through the ruins and palaces left in Udaipur, Jodhpur, Bikaner which attract tourists all over the globe. These beliefs, some deepened, some shattered, some changed for the better still persist today. This article tries to draw connections between these cultural norms, values and stereotypes with suicide rates in present day Rajasthan.



¹ The word "Mewar" here is used to symbolize ancient Rajasthan and to remind the reader of Rajasthan's history of Kings and Riches. Mewar is known to be one of the most fierce independent Rajput regions of pre colonial India.

Comparing Rajasthan with India: The Setting

Suicide is a complex multifaced issue which effects famlies worldwide. Every single life lost to suicide would have had chains of admirers linked to them, for whom, life would never be the same. As a quote reads out – “Suicide does not take the pain away, it gives it someone else”. While looking at suicide data present in hundreds and thousands we tend to forgot that these numbers are not mere points, rather every number, a story of it’s own, and, definitely not a one that has a happy ending.

In India, the incidence of suicide varies significantly between states and social\$ groups. Despite suicides being complex and multifaced issues, there do exist some patterns; One could observe the trends in suicide rates across different states as time passes or dwell deep into the composition of suicides. In this article I look at suicides in Rajasthan and exploring a possibility of a paradox — Strict cultural norms and lower rates of suicide.

Mean suicide rates over the years in Rajasthan has been relatively lower. This was a shock for me. I was expecting suicides to be fairly high in Rajasthan which had a prejudice behind it. I expected states with poor human development indicators such high literacy, education levels, GDP per capita etc to have higher suicide rates based on my assumption that the better the HDI ², the higher standard of living and less likely one is going to suicide. Rajasthan is a state I associate with lower levels of education and a population over reliant on agriculture in a drought prone state; hence, I assumed I would see higher suicide rates.

Figure (1) disproves the same. Had states been ranked according to suicides, Rajsthan would always appear below 50% of all observations, i.e, suicides in Rajasthan as below the median level in India. Table(1) points toward a more evident difference; Rajasthan is compared against four agricultural states in different regions of India. It is evident that the suicide cases in Rajasthan are lower, and significantly lower. The mean suicides in Rajasthan, when looking as whole or segregating based on occupation, are nearly a third lesser as compared to other states. This sets the up room for questions – Despite poor socio-economic performance, why do not see a jump in suicides on Rajasthan.

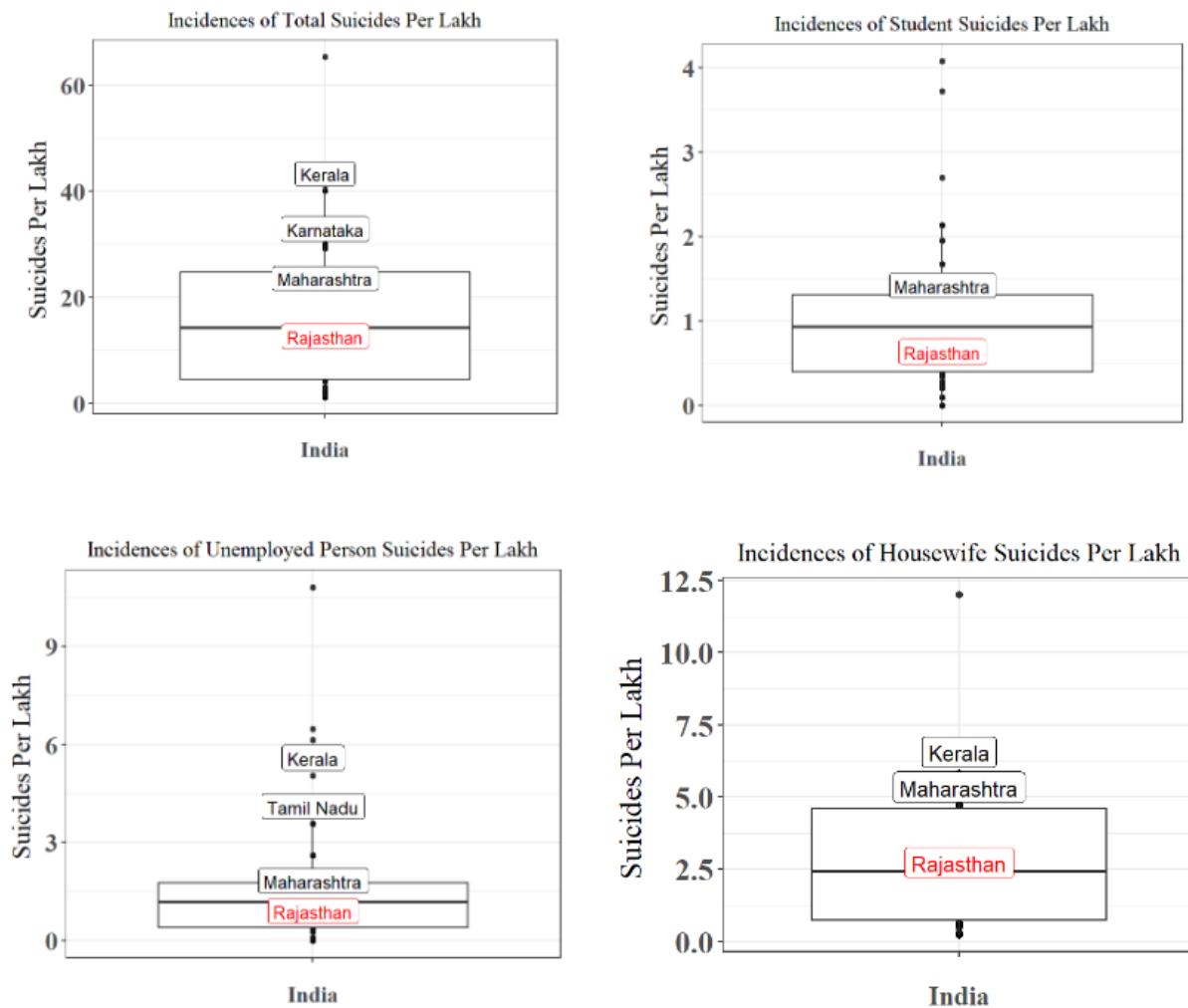
The history and the culture of the people of Rajasthan might be one possible answer which we will look into in the next section.

² The Human Development Index (HDI) is a summary measure of average achievement in key dimensions of human development: a long and healthy life, being knowledgeable and having a decent standard of living.

Table 1: Looking at Number of Suicides by Occupation Across Agricultural States all over India

			Min	Median	Mean	Max
1	Total Suicides	Rajasthan	3195	4392	4310	5166
		Kerala	8431	8858	8931	9810
		West Bengal	11658	14479	13457	16482
		Karnataka	10945	12217	12084	12753
2	Student Suicides	Rajasthan	112	204	196	256
		Kerala	246	281	295	418
		West Bengal	680	842	839	1141
		Karnataka	368	508	519	711
3	Housewife Suicides	Rajasthan	684	916	913	1100
		Kerala	950	1323	1296	1513
		West Bengal	1980	3100	2889	5020
		Karnataka	1275	1826	1815	2225
4	Farmer Suicides	Rajasthan	268	505	524	851
		Kerala	820	1035	1079	1583
		West Bengal	726	993	883	1518
		Karnataka	1403	2100	2093	2678
5	Unemployed	Rajasthan	97	162	163	215
		Kerala	545	1070	1126	2095
		West Bengal	624	1158	1110	1748
		Karnataka	420	589	614	924

Figure 1: Box Plot Representing Occupational Distribution of Mean Suicides in India from 2001-2014



Drawing from the Past and Present: The Characters

Padmavati, a 2017 film, starring Deepika Padukone, Raveer Singh and Shahid Kapoor, depicts the rich culture of Rajasthan well. It is the story of Padmavati, the queen of Mewar, and her husband, Maharaj Ratan Singh. The film is a great starting point if one wants to get a glimpse into Rajasthani culture. We see values of deep devotion towards their families and kingdom. It also talks about the strict cultural norms of the people of Rajasthan, which could lead to even lead to adverse effects and higher suicide rates; housewife suicide in Rajasthan draws along similar lines. This film is relevant to suicides in Rajasthan, not for showcasing jauhar³, but the strict norms cultures have across different states and how cultural emphasis on family and community can be a protective factor against suicide.



³ Jauhar was an Indian practice of mass self-immolation by women, in the Indian subcontinent, to avoid capture, enslavement and rape by an invading army, when facing certain defeat during a war.



Digressing from Padmavat, I would like to share my story of interaction with the Rajasthani culture where my mom spent her childhood. I grew up in Bangalore but during my summer vacations in primary and middle school we used to travel to Punjab to my grandmother's place, which was a marwadi household. Over the years I have grown to get a fair idea rajasthani culture to draw small connections between what I observed and how it links rajasthani cultures with lower rates of suicides.

My mom's generation is the first generation to live in a nuclear family, here at bangalore. I was lucky to witness how fun living in a joint family was as a child. You will always have a task up your head or could perhaps spend the entire day playing cards with *nanaji and his brothers* or go the park with the eldest sibling and eat two ice creams secretly or look at everyone cooking to feed nearly 20 people and enjoy the chaos. To feel isolated is hard as there is someone to cheer you up and take you on a ride for tasty golgappas Or pakoras. We also had a *badi ma* in our house to whom everyone could too without any hesitation and without any fear.

There is also a strong emphasis on family and problems of the family and members of the family will help discuss issues troubling the individual and solve them together. Another side to the entire story is - honor. A darker side. The dark senseless side. A family's honor is considered of utmost importance as the elderly believe that it is a culmination of generations of hard work. Protection of family heritage and respect in society are regarded highly. Suicide is something which will bring "shame" to the family. Connecting all the dots together, it now paints a picture of how strict cultural norms and the culture of a place might have an impact on the suicide rates of the state.

In the next section, I look at how plenty of human development indicators such as literacy rates, household sizes and proportion of SC/ST populations based on PCA Census data are not in Rajasthan's favor making cultural norms a stronger explanation.

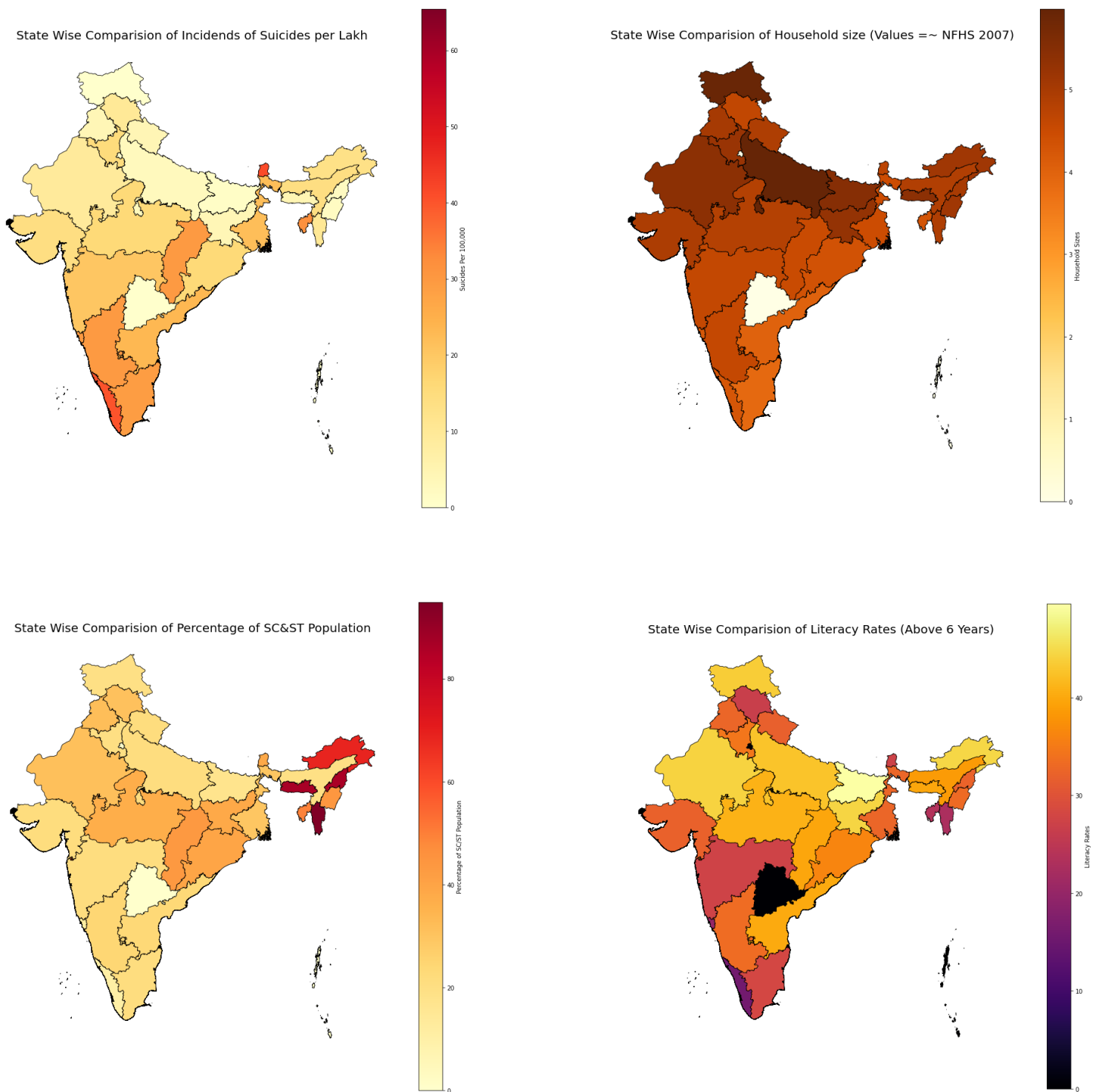
Paradox of Lower Literacy, Bigger Household Sizes, Plenty of Marginal Workers & Strict Norms & Lower Suicide Rates : The Point of View

An answer to "Why do we get educated?" could range from higher wages or to improve one's standard of living, or to benefit the society. Asking similar questions relating to development indicators, for example, literacy and health, would yield similar answers, which is to improve your standard of living. Economists all over the world have econometrically proven that an increase in your education levels or favoring demographic indicators such as belonging to a higher caste tend to have a positive relation with your wages. An increase in your education level for instance, or belonging to a higher caste will yield higher wages. An increase in your wage will improve your standard of living and happiness as you would now be loaded with less constraints. Based on this argument, it would not be incorrect for one to imagine that better development indicators would result in lower suicide rates. Is that right? Does data paint the same picture?

Kerala has very high literacy rates, it also has a lower proportion of SC/ST individuals, the household size is also smaller, yet it has nearly the highest suicides per lakh (Ref Figure: 2). **A more literate population and a HDI value of 0.7(2010) categorized as “High Human Development” and nearly the best state in human development indicators, also has the most suicides!** Rajasthan, a state with very low literacy rates, higher proportion of SC/ST individuals, large household size, and rampant unemployment, yet it has relatively very low suicides per lakh (Ref Figure: 2). **A more illiterate population and a HDI value close to 0.5(2010) categorized as “Low human development ” and nearly the best state in human development indicators, has low suicide rates!** – This is the paradox I have been referring to.

In the next section, I look at occupational trends within Rajasthan and argue that despite relatively lower suicide rates, suicide is still a great deal of worry and talk about trends in student and housewife suicides; whilst, making relevant news citations..

Figure 2: Statewise Comparison of Mean Suicides in India from 2001-2014 (NCRB Data) with Selected Development Indicators from PCA 2011



Changing Perspectives - Housewives, Farmers & Students

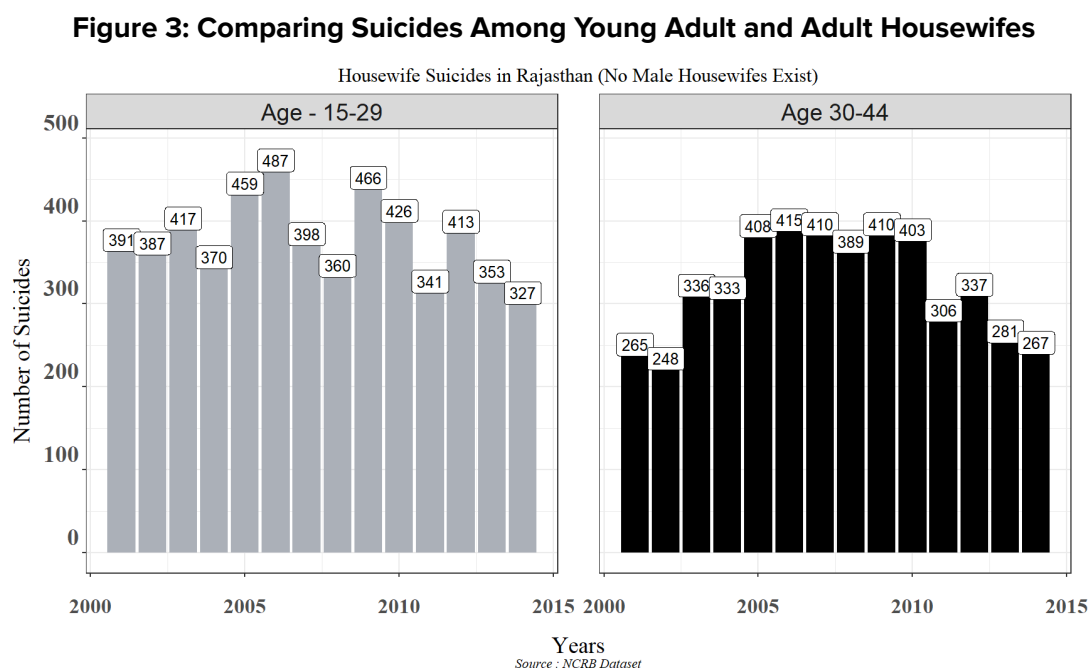
Suicides: The Plot & Conflict

The state of suicides in Rajasthan is quite alarming. Student Suicides is on a rise since 2007 for both males and females. A majority of all female suicides above the age of 15 are housewives (>70%). Emergence of test and coaching centers in the coaching capital of India alongside high fees and low acceptance rates in colleges could perhaps explain the rise in student suicides across genders. Strict gender roles, conformity to strict cultural norms, such as the unjust expectation to be obedient to husbands translating to domestic violence might explain why housewives form a nearly the entire chunk of female suicides in Rajasthan.

The conditions of women in Rajasthan are pathetic, strict norms and bad stereotypes can have adverse effects on women's mental health.

“Women are very excited about the wedding itself but then once the reality of the marriage hits, it becomes an abusive prison, [She added] such are the dynamics of Indian society that they end up isolating women. Even when they are mistreated, usually their family asks them to ‘adjust,’ causing them further despair, which she feels is one of the primary reasons leading housewives to suicide.” (Deepa Narayan, Social scientist)

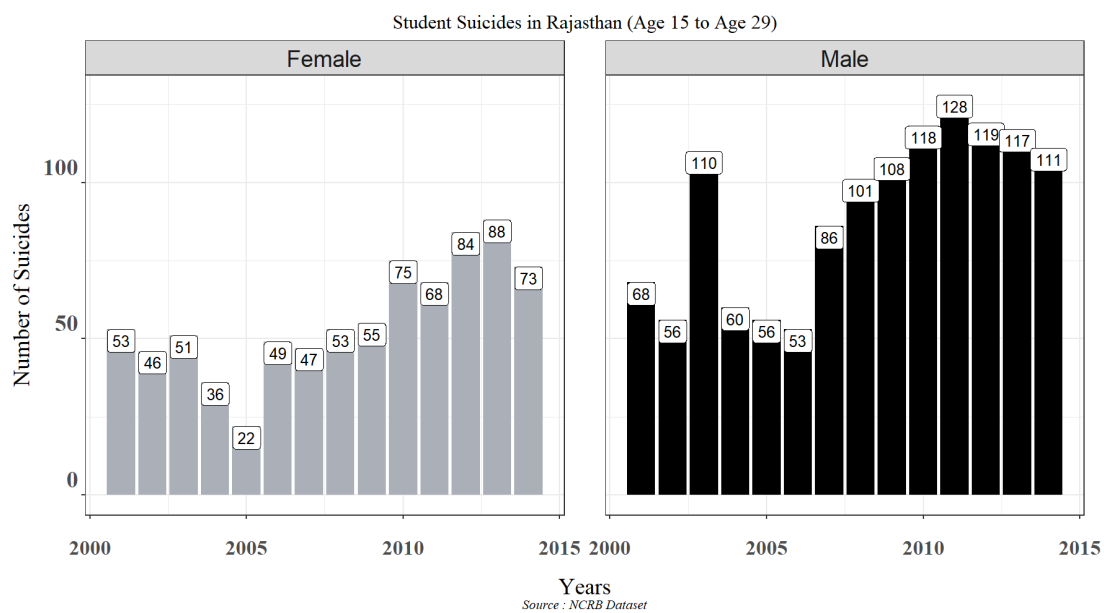
Abusive cultural norms and backward traditions make matter worse for the women of Rajasthan.



Student suicides in Rajasthan have been on a rising trend for both genders with sudden jumps over the years. After the launch of Kota Factory, student suicides in Kota, Rajasthan came into limelight. Here is snippet from a recent article in Hindustan Times on student suicides –

“As many as 121 students have died by suicide in Kota since 2011. In 2022, the number of suicide cases reached 15. The rising toll has always raised questions on the process of coaching, admission and preparation for competitive exams at these coaching centers.”

Figure 4: Comparing Suicides Among Male and Female Students





Data Inaccuracy and Problem in NCRB Data Collection & Interpretation: The Plot Twist?

Here is a snippet from the Final End Term Project we (Akshara, Chankya, Hami, Vaibhav) had worked relating to the NCRB data collection and legitimacy which talks about Data Inaccuracy and Problem in NCRB Data Collection & Interpretation—

“The Crimes in India report released by the NCRB has been usually accepted at face value and data analysis relying on its statistics is presented as the absolute truth, which is far from being the case. For a number of reasons, it is seriously inaccurate to interpret the NCRB report’s data as a representation of the actual level of crime in India. The obstacle to drawing such an inference is that crime reporting cannot be regarded as a reliable measure of real crime incidence. The NCRB relies on crimes reported in police stations to compile the database. When it comes to the Indian State, nothing could be more flawed. Some elements that frequently work to discourage crime reporting include societal and institutional pressures, inadequate protection, and a lack of assistance to victims. In order to offer a complete picture, unofficial polls designed to estimate the true level of crime incidence are frequently done in conjunction with such reports. Unfortunately, the NCRB hasn’t carried out any such exercise. For that reason, an increase or decrease in the crime rate cannot be taken at face value.

While the realization of the imminent issues with crime data collection and interpretation is widely acknowledged. In recent years, no active action has been taken to resolve them. A larger and diverse body including bureaucrats, police officers, social scientists, legal scholars, journalists, and members of the civil society should be constituted to re-evaluate the existing broad categories of crime, system of collecting crime data, and presenting it in the annual reports”

Ending Explained...

This article tries to draw connections between cultural norms, values and stereotypes with suicide rates in present day Rajasthan. The mean suicides in Rajasthan, when looking as whole or segregating based on occupation, are nearly a third lesser as compared to other states. This sets the up room for questions – Despite poor socio-economic performance, why do not see a jump in suicides on Rajasthan. A possible reason could be a strong emphasis on family and problems of the family. Suicide is something which will bring "shame" to the family; in rajasthani culture, a families honor is of utmost importance, forming a barrier to take the extreme measure of suicide. Connecting all the dots together, it paints a picture of how strict cultural norms and the culture of a place might have an impact on the suicide rates of the state.

Strict social norms become an even powerful explanation when we look at Kerala and Rajasthan. Kerala has very high literacy rates, it also has a lower proportion of SC/ST individuals, the household size is also smaller, yet it has nearly the highest suicides per lakh, Rajasthan, a state with very low literacy rates, higher proportion of SC/ST individuals, large household size, and rampant unemployment, yet it has relatively very low suicides per lakh.

The state of suicides in Rajasthan is quite alarming. Student Suicides is on a rise since 2007 for both males and females. A majority of all female suicides above the age of 15 are housewives (>70%). Emergence of test and coaching centers in the coaching capital of India alongside high fees and low acceptance rates in colleges could perhaps explain the rise in student suicides across genders. Strict gender roles, conformity to strict cultural norms, such as the unjust expectation to be obedient to husbands translating to domestic violence might explain why housewives form a nearly the entire chunk of female suicides in Rajasthan.

To sum it all up, the trends in suicide all over india are quite alarming; Suicides are complicated and it is hard to point point a list of cause and how to prevent suicides. Social norms may influence suicides, however, what goes inside an individual's head is impossible to tell. Each life lost due to suicide has a story, not just limited to the individual but all other around him. I will end with a quote I have used before in this article – "Suicide does not take the pain away, it gives it to someone else"



References

- [1] PCA 2011
- [2] Crime Data Suicides 2001-14
- [3] Suicides in India, 2001-2012.
- [4] Padmavati, Sanjay Leela Bhansali, 2017
- [5] Kota Factory, Raghav Subbu, 2021
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- [8] 17-year-old coaching student dies by suicide in Rajasthan's Kota, Jaipur News, Jan 16 2023, HindustanTimes, <https://www.hindustantimes.com/cities/jaipur-news/17yearold-coaching-student-dies-by-suicide-in-rajasthan-s-kota-101673861874460.html>



Appendix of a Few Interesting

Here are some graphs which are interesting and showcase plenty of trends; however, could not make it to the final assignment.

